

When our family chose Vista over six years ago, we believed in its founding vision: a school where academic excellence, performing arts, and technology would work together to help every child reach their full potential. We believed Vista would recognize hard work, dedication, talent, and commitment while providing every student with an equal opportunity to grow.

Instead, our experience became one of years of frustration, unanswered questions, and fighting simply to be heard and treated fairly.

Despite years of outside training, extensive performance experience, and a level of dedication that far exceeded many of her peers, our child was repeatedly overlooked for opportunities while new or significantly less experienced students continued to advance. Year after year we watched qualified students including our own child be held back while others moved forward. Every time we asked why, we received vague explanations and references to “holistic criteria,” but never a clear, objective rubric or transparent scoring process.

As a parent, I repeatedly asked for the same basic information any parent should be entitled to at a public charter school. What exactly was the rubric? How were auditions scored? What weight was given to acting, singing, dance, experience, academics, behavior, attendance, teamwork, or any other factor? Who scored the auditions? Were all teachers using the same scoring system? Could parents review the scores or receive meaningful feedback?

The answer was always the same: “holistic criteria.”

There were no objective scoring sheets provided, no transparent rubric, no meaningful explanation, and no accountability that parents could review. I was ultimately told that the program had historically been run more like a private or community theatre program than a public school. That answer was deeply concerning because Vista is not a private theatre company it is a public charter school where fairness, consistency, transparency, and equal opportunity should be fundamental principles.

Over the years, I also observed what appeared to be a recurring pattern in which children of staff members frequently received lead roles, solos, double casting, and placement into the elite MDT companies. Combined with the absence of transparent criteria, this understandably created a perception

among many families that opportunities were not always being awarded through an objective and consistent process.

What troubled us most, however, was that our child's documented disability eventually became the explanation for why she was not advancing. Yet during six years at Vista, not one performing arts teacher or any teacher ever requested an IEP meeting because of behavioral concerns, recommended additional supports, implemented accommodations within the performing arts program, or documented concerns indicating our child was unable to participate successfully. Those concerns only surfaced after we began questioning the fairness of the process and discussing formal complaints.

After months of persistent advocacy, countless meetings with teachers, administration, Dr. Blasko, multiple formal complaints, and ultimately involving the IEP team, our child was finally given the opportunity that had been denied for years.

Our request was never for special treatment.

We simply wanted the same transparent criteria, the same objective standards, and the same opportunity every student deserves to advance based on merit, effort, and ability under a process that is fair, consistent, and accountable.

Ironically, once finally given that opportunity, every concern that had been used to justify years of exclusion disappeared. Our child kept pace with her peers, met expectations, performed successfully, and demonstrated that the repeated claims she was "not ready" were simply not reflected in reality.

That experience forever changed how we viewed Vista.

Today, this is no longer simply about one student or one family. It is about transparency, accountability, equal opportunity, and ensuring that no child especially one with a documented disability is excluded through undefined "holistic" standards that cannot be explained, reviewed, or applied consistently.

We still believe in Vista's founding mission. We believe in its students, its teachers, and the extraordinary potential of this school. But we also believe that parents deserve transparency, meaningful involvement, and confidence that decisions affecting our children are made fairly and consistently.

That is why we have become involved not to divide the Vista community, but to help restore the trust, fairness, accountability, and collaborative spirit that made Vista such a special place to begin with and that ALL children have a chance to excel, and are treated fairly and with respect with or without disabilities.

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